

Maladaptive Behaviour Caused by Interpersonal Overdependence

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Human interdependence, while inherently a core component of our everyday lives, may prove to cause unsteady development. As a consequence of the normative availability of physical and financial resources as we age, these physical needs thereby lend themselves to individual struggles for a balance between autonomy and dependency (Fiori, et al., 2008). Furthermore, dependent individuals are often described to be anxious, conscientious, and clingy, particularly when required to act autonomously (Bornstein, 2012). This concept has since been referred to as interpersonal dependency, which encompasses the complexity of human emotions and behaviours towards the desire to associate closely with other people (Hirschfield, et al., 1977). As opposed to other attributes, Hirschfield, et al. (1977) discovered that lack of self-confidence is almost exclusive to dependency. Hutchins and Raith (2014) extend these tendencies to the development of maladaptive behaviours, where those who are overly dependent often struggle to adjust appropriately to their environment. As such, the current study aims to unveil the extent to which the human tendency to overly depend on one another induces maladjustment. By introducing destructive overdependence, it is evident that too much emotional reliance is consistent with increased neuroticism and fearful attachment, leading to the development of maladaptive behaviour.

Destructive Overdependence (DO)

Within the realm of dependency research, it has been well-established that there exists three forms of interpersonal dependence: dysfunctional detachment, healthy dependence, and destructive overdependence (Hutchins & Raith, 2014). Most critical to

maladaptive behaviour is destructive overdependence, where Fiori, et al. (2008) characterize it as inflexible and nonreciprocal, developing as early as childhood. As children are taught to rely on authority figures to nurture and guide them, they are contrastingly encouraged to practice responsibility and independence. Hence, trying to determine the appropriate action to take may inflict conflict in the child's cognitive processes due to a lack of familiarity (Bornstein, 2012). Additionally, those with destructive overdependence often set unrealistic interpersonal goals for their relationships, reducing the benefits of emotional support and instead causing frustration and depression when these goals are not achieved (Fiori, et al., 2008). As opposed to adapting to this stress, Fiori, et al. (2008) denote that overdependence instigates excessive demands on such relationships, therefore damaging both the relationship and the well-being of the overdependent individual. For these reasons, the strain that interpersonal overdependence creates will leave these individuals vulnerable to maladaptive behaviours, including neurotic tendencies and insecure attachment styles.

Increased Neuroticism

Individuals undergoing destructive overdependence were consequently found to carry substantial levels of neuroticism, leading them to be more susceptible to depression and other negative feelings (Fiori, et al., 2008). Most notable to interpersonal overdependence is the presence of anxiety, which is stimulated by fears of abandonment and insecurity when it comes to functioning autonomously (Bornstein, 2012). In their book, *The Neuropsychology of Anxiety*, Gray and McNaughton (2024) elucidate that anxiety is a result of overactivity in the hippocampus, producing excess output projected to the amygdala. As the source of the arousal output in behavioural

inhibition, increased activity in the amygdala will therefore lead to maladaptive coping mechanisms such as avoidance, low self-disclosure, and depression (Gray & McNaughton, 2024; Hutchins & Raith, 2014). Moreover, such neurotic traits engendered by overdependence can possibly induce Social Anxiety Disorder (SAD), a pervasive excess of fear under social situations (Hutchins & Raith, 2014). Yan Chen (2018) further scrutinizes the role of interpersonal relationships on confidence and self-esteem, claiming that they are absolutely essential to a person's development, where self-esteem has a decisive role in adaptive responses to stress. As those with destructive overdependence are more vulnerable to lowered self-esteem, they seek constant reassurance, fearing that they will make undesirable impressions while socializing (Hutchins & Raith, 2014). Hence, outcomes of behavioural inhibition emerge, disabling overdependent individuals from meaningfully adapting to stressful situations (Gray & McNaughton, 2024).

Insecure Attachment Styles

Interpersonal dependency as a concept is based upon the formation of a strong emotional bond with another person. The issue, however, arises when one starts to doubt their capacity to function independently without the influence of the other individual (Hirschfield, et al., 1977). Such behaviours are more recognized in children, as researchers have extensively studied different attachment styles in children's problem-solving skills. In the face of adversity, Lynch (2013) found that children who were securely attached sought help only when they struggled to manage a challenge. This allowed them to benefit immensely from their willingness, whereas children who were anxiously attached benefited less as their readiness to seek help hindered them

from functioning autonomously (Lynch, 2013). Even during adulthood, the insecure attachment of a dependent person is reflected by immature, impulsive, and impatient behaviours, causing them to be more susceptible to physical and mental illnesses (Bornstein, 2012). These consequences, largely due to the lack of decisiveness, thus lead overdependent individuals to succumb to maladaptive behaviours (Fiori, et al., 2008). Instead of problem-solving, those who are overly dependent may therefore seek wrongful coping mechanisms such as hostility or falling into a depressive state.

Conclusion

With the many obstacles faced daily, seeking comfort from someone else may be imminent, especially when formed as a habit. However, it is apparent that relying too much on others has caused debilitating effects on one's mental stability, as well as their ability to function independently. Thus, it is not uncommon to find those who are interpersonally overdependent to lean into maladaptive coping strategies as factors of destructive overdependence, neuroticism, and insecure attachment raise cause for concern.

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